Chapter Twenty-Two

Saladin

Between 1171 and 1188, Saladin seizes his master's lands and retakes Jerusalem

WHILE HIS MASTER Nur ad-Din celebrated the unification of the Muslim states from Edessa to Cairo, Saladin, the deputy governor of Egypt, began to close his own hands around his domain.

Saladin's biographer ibn Shaddad, determined to paint his subject as the ideal Muslim ruler, gives us inadvertent glimpses of the real man: a devout believer, but also pragmatic, hardheaded, calculating. He studied his faith, but "his studies did not dig too deep" or lead him into unpopular theological controversy. He fasted during Ramadan, but his fasts "fell a little short" when the demands of war called him to be at his strongest. He never made the *hajj*, the pilgrimage to Mecca that would have taken him away from his restless realm: "He always intended and planned it," ibn Shaddad explains, "[but] was prevented because of lack of time." His desire to see Islam triumph was genuine: "In his love for the Jihad on the path of God he shunned his womenfolk, his children, his homeland, his home and all his pleasures, and for this world he was content to dwell in the shade of his tent with the winds blowing through it left and right."[1]

But this did not eclipse his personal ambitions, as became very clear to Nur ad-Din in October of 1171. Saladin had invaded Crusader territory and laid siege to the southern castle of Montreal. He was close to forcing its surrender when Nur ad-Din approached from the opposite side. Rather than